

HOUSE RESOLUTION 136

By Parkinson

A RESOLUTION to honor the incomparable Anita Ward.

WHEREAS, the members of this legislative body take great pleasure in recognizing a gifted singer whose music has brought joy to millions of people around the globe; and

WHEREAS, a native of Memphis, Anita Ward is universally known for her 1979 million-selling, chart-topping R&B/disco hit "Ring My Bell"; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Ward earned a degree in psychology from Rust College and embarked upon a teaching career before signing a recording contract in the late 1970s; and

WHEREAS, while recording her debut album, *Songs of Love*, Anita Ward was presented with a song that was intended to capitalize on the current disco trend in music; although she was reluctant at first, she agreed to record "Ring My Bell" as a dance track; and

WHEREAS, the resulting single made history, as "Ring My Bell" quickly earned Gold classification and shot up to No. 1 on the Hot 100, R&B, and Dance charts in the United States, also reaching No. 1 in the United Kingdom and Canada; and

WHEREAS, *Songs of Love* reached No. 8 on the U.S. Album and No. 2 on the R&B Album charts; and

WHEREAS, after recording a follow-up album, *Sweet Surrender*, Ms. Ward paused her music career; she returned to the studio to record a third album in 1989, but soon thereafter, she took another hiatus from the industry to focus on raising her daughter; and

WHEREAS, Anita Ward returned to the spotlight on New Year's Eve 2002, performing "Ring My Bell" in New York City's Times Square before one million revelers as part of the city's official celebration; and

WHEREAS, she returned to her roots on New Year's Eve 2005, singing "Ring My Bell" and several other disco songs on Beale Street in Memphis; and

WHEREAS, on January 23, 2024, Anita Ward performed "Ring My Bell" at the First Ladies of Disco Show in Las Vegas, Nevada, to the great delight of the enthusiastic audience; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Ward and her enduring legacy are featured in the 2024 PBS series *Disco: Soundtrack of a Revolution*; and

WHEREAS, Anita Ward took the nation's dance floors by storm with "Ring My Bell," and she remains one of this State's most beloved musical artists; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, that we honor the incomparable Anita Ward, reflecting upon her contributions to popular music, and extend to her our best wishes for every success in her future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy.